

Unit Five

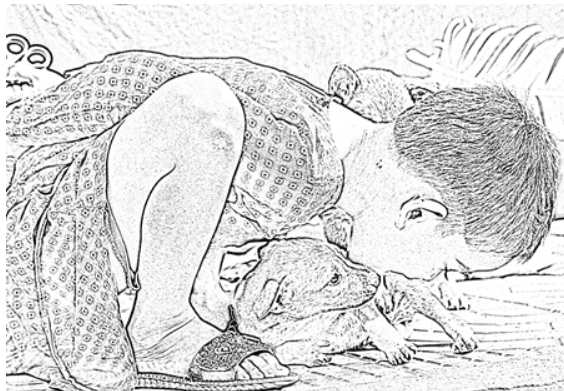
Humans and Environment



Sketch: Charlie Mackesy

After we have studied the unit, we will be able to

- understand the relationship between human beings and nature
- sympathise with the different species living on planet earth
- read and understand texts
- ask and answer questions
- write the main ideas in our own words



Lesson 1: The Little Bird

Key phrases: bird-catching net, gasping for breath, caged bird, let it go, picture books

A . Look at the sketch and discuss with your classmates what you see in it:



B . Read the story by Leo Tolstoy and answer the questions that follow:

It was Seryozha's birthday, and he received many presents: tops, hobby-horses and picture books. But the best gift of all was from his uncle. It was a net for catching birds.

A little board was attached to a frame on which a net was stretched. Grain was sprinkled on the board, and then the net was set out in the yard. When a bird flew up and perched on the board, the board would turn over and the net would fall.

Seryozha was so happy that he came running to his mother to show her his net. His mother said, "It's not a nice toy at all. What do you want to do with little birds? Why do you want to torment them?"

"I'll put them in cages. They'll sing, and I'll feed them." Seryozha got some grain, sprinkled it on the little board and set the net out in the garden. He stood next to it, waiting for birds to come flying down. But the birds were afraid of him and did not come near the net.

Seryozha went in to dinner and left the net in the garden.

When he came to look at it after dinner he saw that the net had fallen and a little bird was thrashing about under it. Seryozha was very excited. He caught the bird and took it into the house.

“Look, Mamma! I've caught a bird. It must be a nightingale. Oh, how fast its heart is beating.”

His mother said, “It's a siskin. Don't torment it. Let it go.”

“No, I'll feed it and care for it.”

Seryozha put the siskin in a cage, and for two days he fed it grain, changed its water and cleaned the cage. On the third day, he forgot about the siskin and did not change its water.

Then his mother said to him, “See? You forgot all about your little bird. I think you had better let it go.”

No, I won't forget. I'll give it some fresh water now and clean the cage.”

Seryozha stuck his hand into the cage and began cleaning it, but the siskin became frightened and beat its wings against the cage. Seryozha cleaned the cage out and went for water.

His mother saw that he had forgotten to close the little door and called after him, “Close the cage door, Seryozha, or your bird might fly out and hurt itself.”

No sooner had she said this than the siskin found the door, spread its wings happily and flew across the room to the window. But it did not see the glass pane. It hit the pane and fell to the windowsill.

Seryozha came running, picked up the little bird and took it back to the cage. The siskin was alive, but it lay on its breast with its little wings spread out and was breathing jerkily.

Seryozha began to cry.

“Mamma! What'll I do?”

“There's nothing you can do now.”

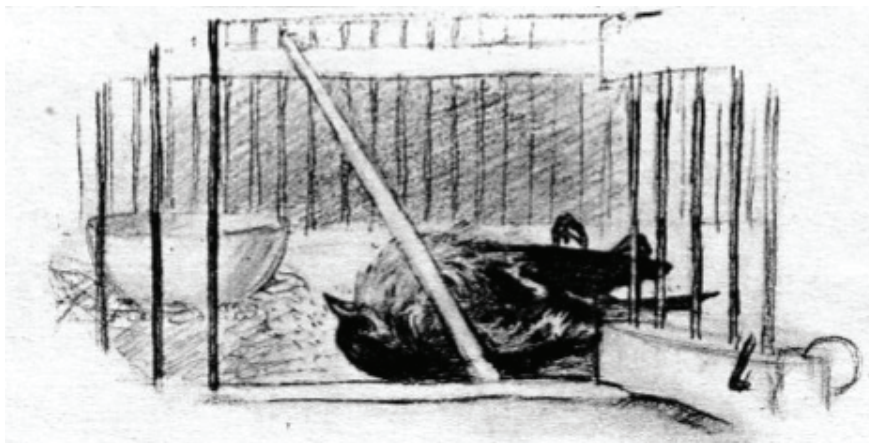
Seryozha did not leave the room that day. He kept gazing at the siskin. The siskin lay on its breast as before, breathing jerkily.

When Seryozha went to bed that night the siskin was still alive.

Seryozha could not fall asleep for a long while. No sooner would he close his eyes than he would imagine the siskin lying there, gasping for breath.

When Seryozha went up to the cage the next morning he saw the siskin lying on its back with its legs curled up. It was dead.

Never again did Seryozha catch another bird.



C. Match the words in Column A with their meanings in Column B;

Column A (Difficult Words)	Column B (Meanings)
1. nightingale	a. a ledge below a window
2. siskin	b. breathing with difficulty
3. thrashing	c. to cause distress or suffering
4. torment	d. a small bird known for its song
5. perched	e. moving violently or wildly
6. jerkily	f. a sheet of glass in a window
7. pane	g. a small songbird related to finches
8. windowsill	h. sitting or resting on something high
9. gasping	i. moving in sudden, sharp motions

D. True or False? If False, write the correct statement:

- Seryozha's mother was happy with the bird-catching net.
- Seryozha caught a siskin using the net.
- Seryozha forgot to feed the bird on the second day.
- The siskin flew into the window after escaping from the cage.
- Seryozha's mother helped him catch the bird.
- Seryozha never tried to catch another bird after the siskin had died.

E. Answer the following questions:

1. What did Seryozha receive as a gift from his uncle?
2. Why did Seryozha's mother not like the idea of catching birds?
3. What kind of bird did Seryozha catch in the net?
4. How did Seryozha take care of the bird at first?
5. If you were in Seryozha's place, what would you have done differently after catching the siskin?

F. Make a list of birds in your locality and categorise which are wild and which are domestic?

Lesson 2: Poems about Nature

A. Look at the image and discuss in groups the possible answers to the questions:

1. What could be the colours of the field, the trees and birds?
2. Where are the birds going?

B. Now read the poem by Rachel Field and answer the questions that follow:

Something Told the Wild Geese

Something told the wild geese
It was time to go.
Though the fields lay golden
Something whispered, — "snow".

Leaves were green and stirring,
Berries, luster-glossed,
But beneath warm feathers
Something cautioned, — "Frost".

All the sagging orchards
Steamed with amber spice,
But each wild breast stiffened
At remembered ice.

Something told the wild geese
It was time to fly,—
Summer sun was on their wings,
Winter in their cry.

-Rachel Field

Note:

lustre-glossed – shiny and smooth.
cautioned – gave a warning.
sagging – hanging down or sinking.
amber – a warm, yellow-brown colour.
stiffened – became hard or tense.
steamed – gave off steam or mist.

C. Answer the following questions:

1. What makes the geese decide to leave?
2. What happens to the leaves and berries in the poem?
3. What changes in nature tell us that winter is near?

D. Read another poem on nature:**Green Escape**

--Joseph Auslander

I have turned my face
Away from streets and crowds
To a windy place
And clouds.

I have turned from skyscrapers
That scratch out the sky,
From wet newspapers
Always whipping by.

I have taken away my heart,
I will give it again
To be split apart
By wind and rain.

I will stand like a stone
All day in the grass
Where the bees drone
And pass and repass.

I will watch them brush
Gold across their legs,
Hear the bird at hush
Over her eggs.

I will hear the wild swan
Lift high and harsh
His crooked clarion
Across the marsh.

Where the jewel-weed hangs,
Where the spotted stream runs,
Where the green beetle bangs
Bronze on bronze—

Rooted in the deep ground,
The sky tugging at my hair,
There will I be found—
There!

Note :

skyscrapers – very tall buildings.

whipping – moving quickly or being blown around by the wind.

drone – a continuous, low humming sound, like bees make.

repass – to pass by again.

clarion – a loud, clear sound, like a trumpet.

marsh – wet, grassy land, often near water.

Jewel-weed – a type of plant with bright orange or yellow flowers.

rooted – fixed firmly in place, like a plant in the ground.

tugging – pulling something with effort.

C. Write a synonym and an antonym for each word from the poem.

Word	Synonym	Antonym
solace		
refuge		
tranquility		
liberation		
respite		

D. Answer the following questions:

1. Why does the speaker turn away from the streets and crowds?
2. What does the speaker hear and see in the grass?
3. How does the speaker describe the sound of the swan?
4. Where does the speaker want to be found at the end of the poem?

Lesson 3: Dancing Bears**A. Read the story by Spencer Holst and answer the following questions:****Brilliant Silence**

Two Alaskan Kodiak bears joined a small circus where the pair appeared in a nightly parade pulling a covered wagon. The two were taught to somer-sault, to spin, to stand on their heads, and to dance on their hind legs, paw in paw, stepping in unison. Under a spot-light the dancing bears, a male and a female, soon became favourites of the crowd. The circus went south on a West Coast tour through Canada to California and on



down into Mexico, through Panama into South America, down the Andes the length of Chile to those southernmost isles of Tierra del Fuego. There a jaguar jumped a juggler, and afterwards, mortally mauled the animal trainer; and the shocked show people disbanded in dismay and horror. In the confusion, the bears went their own way. Without a master, they wandered off by themselves into the wilderness on those densely wooded, wildly windy, subantarctic islands. Utterly away from people, on an out-of-the-way uninhabited island, and in a climate they found ideal, the bears mated, thrived, multiplied, and after a number of generations populated the entire island. Indeed, after some years, descendants of the two moved out onto half a dozen adjacent islands; and seventy years later, when scientists finally found and enthusiastically studied the bears, it was discovered that all of them, to a bear, were performing splendid circus tricks.

On nights when the sky is bright and the moon is full, they gather to dance. They gather the cubs and the juveniles in a circle around them. They gather out of the wind at the centre of a sparkling, circular crater left by a meteorite which had fallen in a bed of chalk. Its glassy walls are chalk white, its flat floor is covered with white gravel, and it is well-drained, and dry. No vegetation grows within. When the moon rises above it, the light reflecting off the walls fills the crater with a pool of moonlight, so that it is twice as bright on the crater floor as anywhere else in that vicinity. Scientists speculate that originally the full moon had reminded the two bears of the circus spotlight, and for that reason they danced. Yet, it might be asked, what music do the descendants dance to? Paw in paw, stepping in unison what music can they possibly hear inside their heads as they dance under the full moon and the Aurora Australis, as they dance in brilliant silence?

Note

Kodiak: A type of bear that comes from Kodiak Island in Alaska.

Somersault: A movement where someone or something rolls over completely in the air or on the ground.

Unison: Doing something at the same time as others.

Jaguar: A large wild cat found mainly in South America.

Mauled: attacked and injured badly by a person or animal

Subantarctic: areas close to but just north of Antarctica

Adjacent: next to or very close to something..

Speculate: to guess or make an assumption about something.

Aurora Australis: a natural light display in the sky near the South Pole.

Meteorite: a piece of rock or metal from space that lands on Earth.

Crater: a bowl-shaped hole in the ground caused by something like a meteorite.

Vicinity: the area around a particular place.

C. Complete the sentences with clues given:

Aurora Australis, travelled, remote, trained, mated, shiny, attacked, deep hollow, shock, pool.

- a) The bears were _____ to perform circus tricks.
- b) The circus _____ south on a West Coast tour.
- c) A jaguar _____ a juggler.
- d) The showpeople disbanded in _____.
- e) The bears wandered off into the _____ islands.
- f) They _____ and multiplied on the island.
- g) The meteorite left a _____ on the island.
- h) The bears danced in a _____ crater.
- i) The light from the moon filled the crater with a _____ of moonlight.
- j) They danced under the moon and the _____.

D. Choose the best answer:

- 1. The primary attraction of the two Kodiak bears in the circus was—
 - a) their ability to speak
 - b) their size and strength
 - c) their dancing and circus tricks
 - d) their hunting skills
- 2. Where did the circus travel after leaving Canada?
 - a) Europe
 - b) South America
 - c) Alaska
 - d) Asia
- 3. What happened to the circus after the jaguar attacked?
 - a) The circus became more popular.
 - b) The showpeople disbanded in fear.
 - c) The bears were rescued by locals.
 - d) The animal trainer survived and continued.
- 4. After being separated from the circus, where did the bears wander?
 - a) into a nearby town
 - b) into the rainforest
 - c) into subantarctic islands
 - d) into the circus tent

5. Why did the bears thrive on the uninhabited island?
- a) They were provided food by local people.
 - b) They found an ideal climate and environment.
 - c) They returned to the circus regularly.
 - d) They learned to fish from local animals.
6. **How long after the circus incident did scientists discover the bears again?**
- a) 20 years
 - b) 50 years
 - c) 70 years
 - d) 100 years
7. **What unusual discovery did scientists make about the descendants of the original bears?**
- a) They had become smaller in size.
 - b) They performed circus tricks naturally.
 - c) They had developed new hunting techniques.
 - d) They had become nocturnal.
8. **The bears gather to dance on nights with a full moon –**
- a) on the shore by the ocean
 - b) in the forest near their dens
 - c) in a crater left by a meteorite
 - d) on a mountain peak
9. **What feature makes the crater where the bears dance unique?**
- a) It is covered with trees and flowers.
 - b) Its walls are chalk white and reflective.
 - c) It is filled with water and fish.
 - d) It is surrounded by glaciers.
10. **What, speculated by scientists, reminds the bear of their circus days?**
- a) the sound of the wind
 - b) the presence of other animals
 - c) the full moon, which resembles the spotlight
 - d) the shape of the island

Lesson 4: The Farming Teacher

A. Talk about the picture and answer the questions:



- 1) What do you see in the picture?
- 2) Do you think that the children are enjoying what they are doing? Tell why.
- 3) Do you think it is important to learn how to farm? Explain.

B. Read the text by Tetsuko Kuroyanagi and answer the following questions:

“This is your teacher today. He's going to show you all sorts of things.” With that the headmaster introduced a new teacher. Totto-chan took a good look at him. In the first place, he wasn't dressed like a teacher at all. He wore a short striped cotton work jacket over his undershirt, and instead of a necktie, he had a towel hanging around his neck. As for his trousers, they were of indigo-dyed cotton with narrow legs, and were full of patches. Instead of shoes, he wore workmen's thick two-toed, rubber-soled socks, while on his head was a rather dilapidated straw hat.

The children were all assembled by the pond at Kuhonbutsu Temple.

As she stared at the teacher, Totto-chan thought she had seen him before. “Where!” she wondered. His kindly face was sun burnt and full of wrinkles. Even the slender pipe dangling from a black cord around his waist that served as a belt looked familiar. She suddenly remembered!

“Aren't you the farmer who works in the field by the stream!” she asked him, delighted.

“That's right,” said the “teacher, with a toothy smile, wrinkling up his face. “You pass my place ev'ry time you go fer yer walks to Kuhonbutsu! That's my field. That one over there full o' mustard blossoms.”

“Wow! So, you're going to be our teacher today, cried the children excitedly.

“Naw!” said the man, waving his hand in front of his face. “I ain't no teacher! I'm just a farmer. Your headmaster just asked me to do it, that's all.”

“Oh yes, he is. He's your farming teacher,” said the headmaster, standing beside him. “He very kindly agreed to teach you how to plant a field. It's like having a baker teach you how to make bread. Now then,” he said to the farmer, “tell the children what to do, and let's get started.”

At an ordinary elementary school, anyone who taught the children anything would probably have to have teaching qualifications, but Mr. Kobayashi didn't worry about things like that. He thought it important for children to learn by actually seeing things done.

“Let's begin then,” said the farming teacher.

The place where they were assembled was besides the Kuhonbutsu pond and it was a particularly quiet section--a pleasant place, where the pond was shaded by trees. The headmaster had already had part of a railroad car put there for storing the children's farming implements, such as spades and hoes. The half-car had a peaceful look, neatly placed as it was right in the middle of the plot they were going to cultivate.

The farming teacher told the children to bring spades and hoes from the car and started them on weeding. He told them all about weeds: how hardy they were; how some grew faster than crops and hid the sun from them; how weeds were good hiding places for bad insects; and how weeds could be a nuisance by taking all the nourishment from the soil. He taught them one thing after another. And while he talked, his hands never stopped pulling out weeds. The children did the same. Then the teacher showed them how to hoe; how to make furrows; how to spread fertilizer; and everything else you had to do to grow things in a field, explaining as he demonstrated.

A little snake put its head out and very nearly bit the hand of Ta-chan, one of the older boys, but the farming teacher reassured him, “The snakes here ain't poisonous, and they won't hurt you if you don't hurt them.”

Besides, teaching the children how to plant a field, the farming teacher told them interesting things about insects, birds, and butterflies, about the weather, and about all sorts of other things. His strong gnarled hands seemed to attest that everything he told the children, he had found out himself through experience.

The children were dripping with perspiration when they had finally finished planting the field with the teacher's help. Except for a few furrows that were a bit uneven, it was an impeccable field, whichever way you looked at it.

From that day onward, the children held that farmer in high esteem, and whenever they saw him, even at a distance, they would cry, “There's our farming teacher!” Whenever he had any fertilizer left he would bring it over and spread it on the children's field, and their crops grew well. Every day someone would visit the field and report to the head-master and the other children on how it was doing. The children learned to know the wonder and the joy of seeing the seeds they had planted themselves sprout. And whenever two or three of them were gathered together, talk would turn to the progress of their field.

Terrible things were beginning to happen in various parts of the world. But as the children discussed their tiny field - they were still enfolded in the very heart of peace.

Note:

dilapidated – in a state of disrepair or ruin due to age or neglect.

furrows – long, narrow trenches made in the ground for planting seeds.

implements – tools or equipment used for a specific purpose.

nuisance – something or someone causing inconvenience or annoyance.

perspiration – the process of sweating.

esteem – respect and admiration, often for someone or something.

attest – provide evidence or proof of something.

gnarled – rough and twisted, often due to age or hard work (usually describing hands or trees).

impeccable – flawless or without any mistakes.

B. True or False? If False, write the correct statement:

1. The headmaster introduced the new teacher as someone who would teach the children to farm.
2. The new teacher was wearing formal attire, including a necktie and dress shoes.
3. The teacher was recognized by Totto-chan as a farmer she had seen before.
4. The children were assembled in a classroom to begin their lesson.
5. The farming teacher reassured Totto-chan that the snakes around the area were not poisonous.
6. The teacher used both hands and words to explain how to plant the field.
7. The children planted the field with the farming teacher's help, but it was messy and uneven.
8. Despite the terrible things happening in the world, the children felt a sense of peace while working on their field.

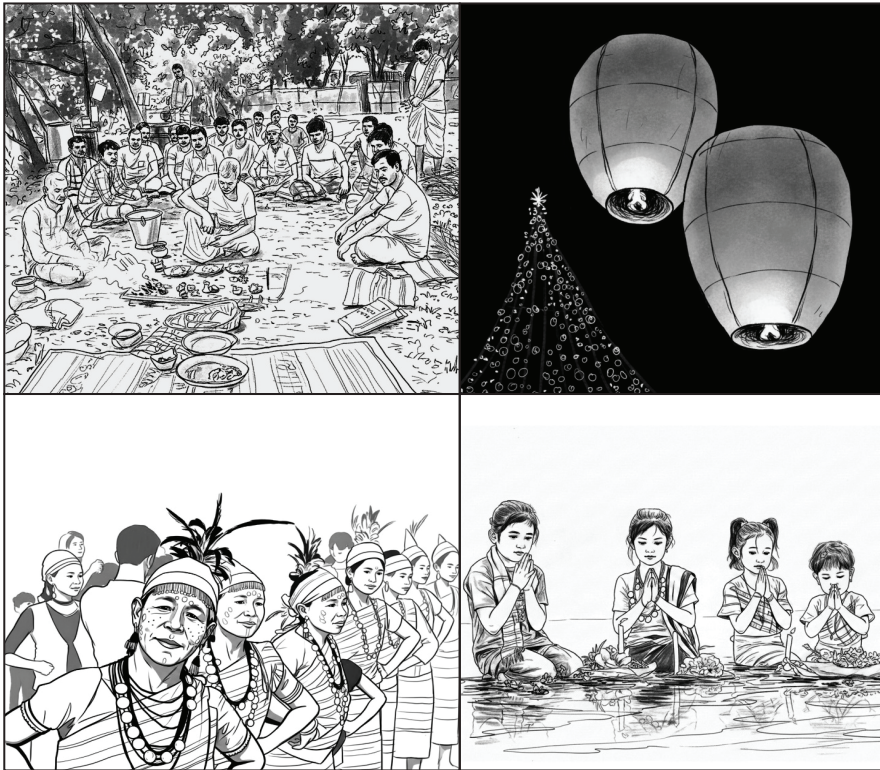
C. Answer the questions below:

1. Who introduced the new teacher to the children?
2. What did the new teacher wear instead of shoes?
3. What were the children going to learn from the farming teacher?
4. How did the farming teacher reassure Totto-chan about the snake?
5. What did the children feel when they saw the seeds they planted start to

D. Have you worked in a crop field before? If yes, share your experience with your friends in the class:

Lesson 5: Beauty of Our Small Ethnic Community Culture

A. Look at the pictures and discuss in groups the possible answers to the following questions:



1. What do you see in the pictures? ?
2. How do the ethnic minority races of Bangladesh preserve their cultural identity?
3. How do the homes and lifestyles of ethnic groups reflect their connection with nature?

Bangladesh is a land of scenic beauty. Many small ethnic communities live peacefully in the hills, plains and forests across the country. Although these communities are small in number, their cultural heritage is very rich and full of beauty. They have their unique way of life, traditions and values. Moreover, these communities carry their individual

identity not only through the foresaid aspects but also through their languages which connects them from generations to generations with their history. Each ethnic group has its own mother tongue that carries the stories, songs and intellectual contributions of their ancestors. Bangladesh government has introduced textbooks in five ethnic languages with a view to protecting their enriched history and culture.

These communities have their own festivals where men, women and children wear colourful and handmade clothes. The design and patterns of these clothes reflect the pride of the richness of their cultural heritage and creativity. Boisabi, Raj Punnah and Kothina Chibar Dan are some of the major festivals celebrated in Chittagong Hill Tracts. Boisabi marks the arrival of Bangla New Year while Raj Punnah is the symbol of their unity and cultural pride. On the other hand, Kothina Chibar Dan is a religious festival which reflects their generosity and spiritual submission. In addition, Sohrai Festival, Wangala Festival, Sangrai Festival and Baha Festival are some other festivals celebrated by the ethnic communities in other parts of the country. Musical instruments, folk songs and traditional dances also carry independent identity of their culture.

Almost all the ethnic groups live in close harmony with nature and, as a result, their homes are made of natural resources. Solidarity and mutual brotherhood is very strong among them. However, in this age of modernisation, these communities are struggling to keep their culture alive. Still, the beauty of small ethnic communities lies in their peaceful lifestyle, strong traditions and deep connection with nature. These communities play vital role in enriching the cultural heritage of our motherland.

B. Match the words in Column A with their meanings in Column B:

Column A	Column B
1. heritage	previously mentioned
2. unique	unlike anything else
3. foresaid	embody or represent
4. enriched	a special or individual possession
5. reflect	make better or improve in quality

C. Read the following passage and fill in the blanks using words given in the box:

valuable	magnificent	active	events
affluence	concord	knowledgeable	liberality

Bangladesh is a land of scenic beauty. Many small ethnic communities live peacefully in the hills, plains and forests across the country. Although these communities are small in number, their cultural heritage is very _____. They have their unique way of life, traditions and values. Each ethnic group has its own mother tongue that carries the stories, songs and _____ contributions of their ancestors. Bangladesh government has introduced textbooks in five ethnic languages to protect their _____ history and culture. These communities celebrate different _____ where people wear colourful and handmade clothes. The design and patterns of these clothes reflect their cultural _____. Among the major festivals celebrated in the Chittagong Hill Tracts are Boisabi, Raj Punnah and Kothina Chibar Dan. Kothina Chibar Dan is a religious festival that shows their _____. Almost all the ethnic groups live in close _____ with nature, and their homes are made of natural resources. However, in this age of modernisation, they are struggling to keep their culture _____.

D. Answer the following questions:

1. How do the minority races of Bangladesh contribute to the cultural diversity of the country?
2. Why has the government introduced textbooks in ethnic languages?
3. How do the traditional clothes and designs reflect the cultural values of ethnic communities?

E. Find out if anyone from your family has visited any ethnic festival mentioned in the text. If so, listen to his/her experience and share it with class.